

Abnormal Uterine Bleeding — Clinical One-Pager

Reproductive-age bleeding outside FIGO norms · define → rule out pregnancy → PALM-COEIN → universal + targeted work-up. Adapted from TeachIM.org (CC BY-NC 4.0); FIGO 2018 / ACOG.

1 · Define: 4 FIGO parameters

Parameter	Normal	Abnormal
Frequency	q24–38 d	<24 frequent; >38 infrequent; none = amenorrhea (no menses ×3 mo)
Duration	≤8 d	>8 d prolonged
Regularity	variation ≤7–9 d	>9 d (≤9 if age <25 or >42; ≤7 if 26–41); intermenstrual spotting
Volume	no interference	subjective; or soak pad/tampon q2h, overnight changes, flooding/clots

2 · PALM-COEIN differential

Step 0: rule out pregnancy in everyone.

PALM — structural	COEIN — non-structural
P Polyp (endometrial>cervical)	C Coagulopathy (vWD, plt, liver/renal)
A Adenomyosis (boggy/tender uterus)	O Ovulatory dysfxn (PCOS, thyroid, prolactin, perimenopause, POI)
L Leiomyoma (fibroid)	E Endometrial (endometritis/PID, STI)
M Malignancy/hyperplasia (endometrial; also cervix/vagina/vulva)	I Iatrogenic — hormonal contraception/IUD/implant, anticoag, SERM, dopamine antagonist N Not yet classified (AVM, isthmocele)

Key fix The "I" = **Iatrogenic**, not "idiopathic" (FIGO 2018).
Prototype = new-IUD/implant spotting.

3 · Universal work-up (ALL patients)

- **Pelvic exam** — non-uterine source? blood from os? enlarged/tender uterus, adnexal mass?
- **3 labs**: pregnancy test · CBC (anemia/thrombocytopenia) · iron studies (**ferritin <50 ng/mL = low** pre-menopause; treat even without anemia)

4 · Targeted tests by clue

Clue	Suspect	Test
HMB since menarche; fam/postpartum/surgical bleeding (~20% of HMB)	Coagulopathy	vWF panel, PT/PTT, factor activity
Hirsutism, insulin resistance, irregular	PCOS/androgen excess	Total testosterone (±17-OHP, DHEAS)
Galactorrhea	Prolactinoma	Prolactin
Weight↑/fatigue/hair loss; or weight↓/heat	Thyroid dysfxn	TSH
Hot flashes, 40s, ↑cycle length	Perimenopause	FSH (±LH)
Dyspareunia, discharge	Endometritis/PID/STI	GC + chlamydia
New IUD/implant/AC/SERM	Iatrogenic	Med review; reassure (settles 3–6 mo)

5 · Structural branch & biopsy

- **TVUS** for uterus/ovaries/endometrial stripe.
- **AUB is the most common symptom of endometrial cancer.**
- **Endometrial biopsy** if: **any postmenopausal bleeding**; age >45; chronic anovulation/obesity; unopposed estrogen (incl. tamoxifen); persists despite rx.

6 · HPO axis & first-line rx

- **Hypothyroid**: ↑TSH → feedback → ↓GnRH → ↓FSH/LH → anovulation.
- **Perimenopause**: ↓ovarian estradiol → lost feedback → ↑GnRH → ↑FSH.
- **Non-structural HMB rx (ACOG)**: levonorgestrel IUD or tranexamic acid first-line; treat underlying cause.

Adapted from TeachIM.org — Abnormal Uterine Bleeding (Zarling, deQuillfeldt, Fainstad, Brett; 2022), CC BY-NC 4.0. FIGO PALM-COEIN 2018 (Munro).
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